

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

They're out to get the Combat Zone!

Anyone who follows the history of declining and renewing neighborhoods in Boston acquires the sure eye of a paranoid for patterns in the news.

Such a pattern has been visible in reports from the Combat Zone for at least the past year. Starting about then, following the murder of Harvard student Andrew Puopolo in the Zone, a lot of people began chorusing that the Zone was a failure.

Among those who said so by words or acts were the Boston police department, the liquor licensing board and the Suffolk County district attorney's office. Tufts-New England Medical Center, whose development officer, Robert Vey, moved to Tufts from the Mayor's staff not long before all this began, talked about cleaning up Tufts' flank. And the Building Owners and Managers Association of the Boston Real Estate Board invoked the classic cancer metaphor, beloved by urban-renewers and city-haters since, literally, the founding of the Republic:

"As building owners and managers in Boston, we are much concerned with the current blight of lower Washington street and the cancerous effect of the Combat Zone on adjacent retail and business firms."

A pattern like this usually means only one thing. Someone is out to make money out of redeveloping the neighborhood, and the first step in doing that is to depress its value as low as possible.

The Zone today could hardly be more depressed. As a result of pressure by public agencies, strip clubs are closing. Buildings are being torched. Where storefront rents two and three years ago were among the city's highest, now they're peanuts. Upper floors are boarded up. If anyone wants to acquire the Zone, it won't cost much.

Why would anyone want it? Simply because it's some of the most valuable real estate in Boston, practically surrounded by new investment.

On the south is Tufts-New England, about to undergo major expansion. To the west, the new state transportation building will revive the next block of Stuart street while other improvements will upgrade the theater district. If Park Plaza ever happens — it's now being re-advertised since its abandonment by developer Mort Zuckerman — that will add further pressure.

To the north, the Lafayette Place redevelopment along Washington street is in the planning stage. To the east, the rapidly growing Chinese community has already begun purchasing in the Zone. Off to one side is the city government, savoring the prospect of new taxes from a redeveloped Zone.

The Combat Zone is a cooked goose on a platter surrounded by hungry diners. It really doesn't deserve that fate.

The idea behind the Zone, which was made official in November 1974, was that the city would accept the fact that there were going to be such things as "adult" uses but that it would limit them to the one small area of lower Washington street where most of them already were.



Boylston Building is Zone's second Landmark structure. It is currently vacant above street level, although overlooking new Liberty Tree park.

Since November 1974, no new adult entertainment use has opened anywhere in the city outside the Zone, and several have closed. Boston is the only major US city where such uses are not spreading. In that sense the Zone is a success.

As for danger, that's largely a matter of perception, not statistics. So far as I know, no one has demonstrated that the Zone is any more dangerous than Back Bay or Beacon Hill. Many feel it's less so. A BRA planner makes the point: About the same time as the Puopolo murder, an acquaintance of the planner was strangled on Mt. Vernon street. No paper or TV station mentioned the crime. It didn't have the myth-power of the killing of a Harvard student in a den of iniquity.

There's a kind of theater of violence in the Zone — pimps lolling on street corners, knives and boots and green berets for sale in what used to be Army-Navy stores — but it's not the real thing. Perhaps we descendants of the Watch and Ward need to believe that sin is seedy and violent, so the Zone merchants play it that way.

Aside from the issue of porn, which it is your constitutional right to have if you want it, the Zone has two virtues that perhaps shouldn't be heedlessly wiped out.

The first is its architecture. Four buildings in the Zone or on its edge have been designated landmarks by the Boston Landmarks Commission. Many others are among the more remarkable structures downtown. It's worth a walk

just to savor the amazing confection in Ruskinian Gothic that houses the Essex Liquor Co. on Essex street. Rare octagonal dormers crown the fine Liberty Tree Building opposite Liberty Tree Park. Next door is the original Peter Bent Brigham Hospital, a handsome mansarded structure. The Boylston Building at Boylston and Washington is another fine one, now vacant above street level. And there are many others.

The Zone's other quality is its true urban intricacy of use and scale. Little alleys dart here and there, buildings and uses of all periods and kinds jostle one another. There's an air of mystery behind the walls that is basic to the appeal of cities. Any overscaled, single-use redevelopment, like Tufts across the street, would destroy all that.

A single building sums the Zone up. Ignored by passersby, the Hayden Building on LaGrange street was designed by one of the world's great architects, H. H. Richardson, in 1875. A shock peepshow defaces the ground floor. The upper walls, which appear to be boarded up and vacant, actually conceal a four-floor gay bathhouse, though no sign tells you so.

That's the Zone: Architecture and shock, mystery and a little sin, plus a lot of theatrics. A carny show that may be about to close.

On the subject of the Institute for Contemporary Art, this quixotic organization is offering an unusual, tour May 5-7. A plane will fly guests to Columbus, Ind., the town justly famed



Hayden Building at corner of LaGrange and Washington symbolizes Combat Zone's special combination of architecture, shock and mystery. Designed by H. H. Richardson, cited by the Boston Landmarks Commission, it houses a peepshow and, behind blanked-out windows and without a sign, a four-story gay bathhouse.

for its more than 40-buildings by such contemporary masters as I.M. Pei, Eero and Eliel Saarinen, Kevin Roche, Cesar Pelli, and many others. For \$350 (which includes a \$50 donation to ICA) you get all fares, a room at the Hyatt Regency, a dinner, special side trips and a visit to the private home and art collection of the legendary J. Irwin Miller, sugar daddy of Columbus and its architect.

It sounds like a unique opportunity.

The Historic Neighborhoods Foundation, following up on its walking tour of downtown last weekend, will sponsor a tour of the Back Bay for members and friends of the Back Bay Association on May 6.